I shat myself. I had no idea what to do and responded very angrily. ‘Don’t talk kak to me,’ I said, and put the phone down. I remember thinking, ‘The fucking witch.’ I had just made the South African team and all I could think to do was to keep it nice and quiet. I didn’t even tell my parents.

I wasn’t sure whether or not Liesl had got pregnant on purpose. I mean, she lived in Joburg and my international career was just taking off. It’s not like I was ever going to make any adjustment to my life to go and look after her. Man, I was pissed off. I had no idea what to do about the situation and I didn’t breathe a word about it to anyone.

My mom found out first. Via the post. Not ideal. This very formal-looking letter arrives in the postbox addressed to ‘Mr H Gibbs’. My dad’s name is Herman, so my mom opened the letter, thinking it was for him. But it was the maintenance contract Liesl’s family lawyer had drawn up. They were asking for R3 000 a month, starting straight away – the kid wasn’t even born yet. That was a lot of money back then, especially for me. It was ridiculous. They must have thought I was loaded.

My mom was like, ‘And this? What the hell is this, Herschelle?’

Man, I was frightened, but I had to come clean. All I could say was, ‘Well, listen, this is the story and this is how much I have to pay. What else can I do?’ I had no choice but to pay the money. Fortunately Liesl became less demanding later on. Maybe she realised that you can’t expect to get that sort of money from anybody.

But I was so angry with her that it took me a year after my son was born before I could actually bring myself to see him. I was in Joburg to see Liesl’s dad about the maintenance and she asked me to come and see Rashard. ‘Look,’ she said, ‘you don’t have to stay with him long. Just come and hold him.’ Her dad was in the car, she was driving, and I was holding Rashard, who was crying. I tried to sort of shut him up, and I remember feeling very cold towards him. It was just this complete anger, you know, for what I figured Liesl had done to me. I couldn’t stop wondering, ‘Did she do it on purpose?’ In hindsight, it was obviously unfair to suspect her of that.

As a result, I didn’t see much of Rashard as he grew up, especially in his early years. Now the situation is improving, though – in the past few years I’ve seen him much more regularly, and I phone and talk to him a lot too. We see each other whenever I’m playing in Joburg, and I’ve also gone to